

reveal before. "I lost \$140,000," he said simply. "And I'm still trying to make it back." He told how a decade ago he'd been making decent money in the agriculture pits, but was lured away by the action in the stock-index-futures pits. After an initial success there, he risked more money on stock-index futures, and even borrowed to add to his stake. One day, the market moved against him and wiped out everything he had. "It took ten years for me to work up to it, but only a single day to nail myself," he said. "One day is all it took."

Since then, he'd been reduced to working for commissions, saddled with the double burden of supporting a family and also paying off his debts. He blamed his troubles not on the sudden, unexpected move in the stock-index futures but on a flaw in his character. This he thought he'd corrected. He hoped someday to trade livestock futures for his own account, the way he'd always done before he self-destructed.

This was the second time I'd heard something psychological—first from Mr. Dickman in the corn pits ("sooner or later you find out who you are") and now from Mr. Hersh ("it only took one day to nail myself"). I was beginning to sense that regular traders didn't see these markets as pits of gold, but rather as a harsh form of reality therapy in which their defects were revealed and they were financially punished for same. The best they could hope was to settle down and make a modest living. This was a long way from the giddy road to riches presented to the general public, and I saw the hardship in the faces of the humble Mr. Dickman, and the soft-spoken and congenial Mr. Hersh.

Meanwhile, LQ-001 walked by, the woman who'd sold me my hogs. I called her to a halt and she introduced herself. "Elizabeth Quattrocki," she said. She was tall, dressed in a tweedy business suit, and looked all of 25. I asked what she was doing in live-hog options. "Trading for the summer," she said. "On my father's account." Her father was an former Shakespeare scholar whom she said I'd find in the live-cattle pit, though Ms. Quattrocki warned me not to go over there. "Don't try to talk to him today," she advised. "You should have talked to him yesterday. The market was limit up yesterday, but today it's off 80."

Ms. Quattrocki guessed that her father made more money off